regime were floundering, the Persian government looked to Britain for aid. As Loraine put it in a letter to Lindsay, the Persians ‘go on hoping that someone will pull their chestnuts out of the fire so that they may take the profits if he succeeds, and he the blame if he don’t [sic]. And there...you have the whole basis, theory and practice of Persian politics.’[38]

In order to sever this traditional fear of Russia, Loraine wanted to break the illusion of Moscow’s capabilities. In a telegram to the Foreign Office in February 1922 he asked to be furnished with information which he could pass on to the Persian government exposing the Bolshevik government’s weaknesses domestically, economically and militarily. Both Gregory and Lindsay, however, saw this as problematic. Many examples could also be found to show Russia’s strength and power, while ultimately the whole scheme appeared too close to the promise made in the trade agreement to refrain from anti-Bolshevik propaganda.[39] Curzon agreed, telling Loraine that the Persian government would no doubt hear for themselves about Russia’s internal problems.[40]

To some extent it suited Britain to have Persia fearful of Moscow anyway. As long as the Persian government remained apprehensive of the Bolshevik regime, and at odds with its representatives in Tehran, Britain was able to cast itself in the role of benevolent arbitrator. Should Persia realise Russia’s bluff, it might give it unwarranted confidence in its own capabilities and further rebuff British proffers of aid. As Curzon wrote on a report by Loraine regarding the friction between the Persian government and the Soviet Legation:

I consider these political crises inevitable and may prove excellent medicine for Persia until she recovers her senses. We should let them succeed each other with mathematical regularity but without showing slightest concern ourselves. One day Persia will knock again at the door of the British Legation.[41]